

Byzantine architecture

When Constantine established Constantinople in 324 CE, the Roman Empire split in two, with a capital city for each half: Constantinople in the east and Ravenna in the west. The subsequent fusing of Greek and Roman styles in the Byzantine (Eastern Roman) Empire led to forms such as the Greek-cross plan church, with its four equal arms, square centre and dome roof. Important buildings featured high ceilings and opulent decoration including marble, mosaics and inlays, although churches tended to feature painted icons in place of statues.

With Constantinople located on so many major trade routes, Byzantine architecture spread across a vast area, influencing medieval, Renaissance and Ottoman styles. Surviving examples include the octagonal basilica of San Vitale in Ravenna (opposite, 547 CE), whose Byzantine elements include a polygonal apse, capitals, narrow bricks and rich mosaics; St Mark's Cathedral in Venice (1092); and the churches of Hosios Loukas (Saint Luke) in Boeotia, Greece, founded in the 11th century.

